I had a bad feeling about the Denmark game beforehand. It might have been due to exhaustion after the heat in Osaka, but I thought there was more to it than that. We knew we'd probably face Brazil if we got through; and people were already looking ahead to that even though we had this game to win first. Denmark were well organized and a physically strong team; almost all their players played in England or, at least, had done so during their careers. I thought it might turn out like our first group game against Sweden, where the opposition's familiarity with the England players had done them a favor but not helped us at all. I believed in this England team. Believed, in fact, that we had a chance in 2002 of doing something that hadn't been done since 1966. But I wasn't sure we'd be in the right frame of mind to turn that into a result on Saturday afternoon.

Before the game, I took one look around and knew I was wrong. We were as ready for Denmark as we had been for Argentina. The players' faces and their body language were just right: no fear, no distractions, no tension. Everyone was focused, waiting for kick-off, more relaxed than I'd ever seen an England team. Niigata was another new stadium for us, but the lads looked like it had only taken the previous evening's training session to make it feel like home. An atmosphere like that amongst players takes on a life of it's own, You look at your mate; he looks like he's up for it. So does your team-mate next to him. And you're radiating confidence yourself by the time the look falls on you. It's an energy that runs through a dressing room in the minutes before kick-off. That afternoon, I knew we were set.

As we came up the tunnel and out on the field, I found myself looking at Denmark's players instead of my team-mates. The way they walked, eyes darting backwards and forwards: you could sense how nervous they were. It maybe wasn't fear exactly, but it was something like it: no self-belief. We had a psychological advantage. The tough guys like Thomas Gravesen and Stig Tofting were doing their best, marching round and growling, as if to say they were up for the scrap. That just made it more obvious that a lot of the other Danish players looked like they didn't welcome it at all. It wasn't only me who noticed. While we were warming up, Rio called across to me.

'What do you reckon? They look scared.'

I think we had Denmark beaten before we'd even kicked off. Which was just as well: it was the one time all summer that the injury really gave me grief during a game. My foot had been feeling better and better, almost by the day. Against Denmark, though, I wore boots with an ordinary long stud. It was pouring with rain in Niigata, so I didn't have any choice. Until then, most